United Kingdom Liaison Mission in Japan,
TOKYO. 141

SECRET
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Dear R.,

I am sorry to have to make still another communication about the Yoshida letter. But I have this afternoon received a call from Mr. Okazaki (who, as you know, is now in virtual charge of the Gaimusho). He said he came at the request of the Prime Minister to give me informally an explanation of the events leading to the publication of the now famous letter. He added that Mr. Yoshida would be acknowledging the letter which I sent to him on 11th February, conveying the Secretary of State's recent statements in the House of Commons, but as this was a very delicate matter, he was reluctant to elaborate on it in writing.

Mr. Okazaki's explanation in brief was as follows. The sympathies of the Liberal Party, which Mr. Okazaki explained was of course Conservative, and of Mr. Yoshida himself were with Nationalist and not with Communist China. The Japanese had not been under any pressure from Mr. Dulles, but he had merely asked them to state these opinions in writing, and Mr. Yoshida had accordingly done so. He had, however, when Mr. Dulles was in Tokyo, made it clear that he would only be willing to do so if some understanding was reached between the United Kingdom and the United States Governments, and he expressed the hope that this understanding might be reached during the then forthcoming visit of Mr. Churchill and Mr. Eden to Washington. Subsequently, he had been given to understand by Mr. Dulles that an understanding had been reached with the British, and he had accordingly issued the letter. Mr. Okazaki wished to make it clear that the Japanese Government had no intention of concluding a treaty with Chiang Kai-shek to cover the mainland of China. They considered the "National Government of the Republic of China" to be a description of a government which did not define its jurisdiction over China; it was merely one of two Governments claiming to be the Government of China. Whereas the Peace Treaty with Japan referred to "the Allied Powers and Japan", the treaty which the Japanese expected to conclude with Chiang Kai-shek would refer only to the Japanese Government and the National Government of the Republic of China, and not to Japan and China. This, he seemed to feel, was a distinction with a difference. Finally, he said that Mr. Yoshida, who as I knew was very attached to Great Britain, was very distressed/

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distressed to think that we supposed he had acted in any way to which we could take exception, and that was why he wanted Mr. Okazaki to explain the position to me.

I thanked Mr. Okazaki for his explanation, which I said I would convey to the Secretary of State. I said my letter to Mr. Yoshida, enclosing the statements made by Mr. Eden in the House of Commons, had been prompted by a report in the press indicating that Mr. Yoshida thought we agreed with the action which had been taken. This question had created quite a stir in Great Britain, and was still the subject of discussion in a Foreign Affairs Debate in the House of Commons which had been interrupted by the King's death. I therefore felt I had to make it quite clear that we could not agree with what had been done, and I reiterated the views of Her Majesty's Government which had not changed since the time when the Treaty negotiations took place. I indicated that at any rate in my view Mr. Yoshida's letter had committed Japan rather more definitely than Mr. Okazaki seemed to think. As to Mr. Okazaki's point about the definition of the National Government of the Republic of China, I was no international lawyer, but I wondered whether the matter could be dealt with as easily as all that.

Mr. Okazaki seemed to be somewhat doubtful whether Chiang Kai-shek's government would be prepared to agree to the Japanese proposals, but he said that if they did, Japan would be prepared to conclude or even sign a treaty, on the understanding that it would not come into force until after the Treaty of Peace with the Allied Powers became effective. He concluded by expressing Mr. Yoshida's renewed and pious hope that eventual understanding would be reached between the United Kingdom and the United States on the question of China.

I do not know that this adds a great deal to what has already been said on the subject. As I have indicated in previous correspondence, the Japanese will never admit that they have been subjected to pressure by the United States because that would involve too great a loss of face. But I still remain of the opinion that the actual terms of the letter were dictated by Dulles. All that Mr. Okazaki had to say seems to show that the Japanese want to get the best of all worlds, which is a Japanese characteristic not unfamiliar to us. I took the opportunity of this conversation, which I have avoided describing in too great detail, to deliver a little homily on the Far Eastern situation as we see it, and, as Mr. Okazaki is easily the most intelligent and efficient Japanese who deals with foreign affairs, I hope that something of what I said may have sunk in.

Yours ever,

Bill Brenning

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